tian Kuki community is one of the affected parties. But it also hit home in Kerala, where just days before the CBCI event, members of the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) had barged into a government upper primary school in archbishop Thazhath's neighbouring district Palakkad and disrupted a Christmas celebration for the young wards. State BJP leaders were quick to distance themselves from the incidents—a Christmas nativity crib was also found vandalised in another school in the same district—even as a few Church elders took to social media to deride the party's "tokenism".



TIT FOR TAT
CPI(M) students' wing take out a Christmas carol rally to protest the VHP disrupting a school X'mas celebration, Palakkad, Dec. 23

SAFFRON STRATEGY

The relatively well-off Roman/Syrian Catholic community in Kerala feels they have found a "good samaritan" in PM Modi. The feeling is mutual, though it does have political undertones. The BJP needs the community's votes in the assembly election scheduled for March-April 2026 and the Lok Sabha polls thereafter in 2029. Though Hindus account for about 55 per cent of the state's population, the party has been unable to consolidate their vote as the Left and the Congress are entrenched entities here. The Christians, who make up some 18 per cent of the vote, could hence be a game-changer for the party.

Winning the Thrissur seat in 2024—where Gopi won with a margin of 74,686 votes—showed the BJP that it was on the right path. Party sources admit it was "Modi Magic along with the Syro-Malabar church" that helped it open its LS account in Kerala. Thrissur has around 24 per cent Christian voters and some 48 per cent Hindu votes. The thumping victory margin sent shock waves through both the Left and the Congress.

It was after the 2014 Lok Sabha election where BJP veteran and ex-Union minister O. Rajagopal lost to the Congress's Shashi Tharoor in Thiruvananthapuram by 15,000-odd votes that the party realised they had to tap the Christian vote. The Latin and Nadar Christian communities in the coastal areas had saved Tharoor from a humiliating defeat. Since then, the central leadership has worked systematically to win over the Christians.

It started with former IAS officer Alphons Kannanthanam being inducted as the Union minister of state for tourism in 2017. But that didn't quite pan out, though he did create inroads with the state's Pentecostal churches. Meanwhile, the 2021 assembly polls rolled in, where the BJP-led NDA lost its only seat and saw vote share fall to 12.4 per cent (a 2.6 percentage point dip from 2016) despite a saturation campaign and multiple Kerala visits by Modi. That was another wake-up call. The party's new point person is George Kurian, the Union MoS for fisheries, animal husbandry and dairying and minority affairs. A Catholic by faith, he is a popular leader in Christian circles. A big part of the outreach now is extending all help for the Pope's visit, scheduled for early 2026, possibly before the state elections.

Some observers believe that for many churches, the newfound love for BJP is a question of "survival"

THE BIG SQUEEZE

Some political observers believe that for many of the churches, this new-found love for the BJP is a question of "survival". According to this view, the community has realised that a Congress resurgence is unlikely nationally and since they have historically been 'allergic' to the Left, the next best option seems to be the saffron club. The 2,000-year-old Syro-Malabar Catholic Church has in the past decade been rattled by internal conflicts, a multi-crore tax evasion probe and criminal charges against former church head Cardinal George Alencherry (in land deals, among other cases), which has offered inroads to the BJP. The Church is one of the most influential in Kerala with interests in healthcare, educational institutions and NGOs. The party is also in touch with the Marthoma Church (which accounts for one million of the faithful) and the Syro-Malankara Catholic Church. As for the fringe denominations, like the Pentecostal Church, they need the BJP's blessings to get their foreign funds released. Their NGOs are struggling with the Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA) that was amended in 2020. A retired senior income tax officer told INDIA TODAY, "I personally headed a raid on one of the gospel church headquarters in Kerala. We unearthed huge amounts of unaccounted-for cash and even interrogated officials and recorded statements. But nothing came of it finally." The raids, say sources, were a signal to the Pentecostal churches to fall in line.

A priest from the Latin Catholic diocese, who didn't want to reveal his identity, confirms this. "The Christians in Kerala are not politically monolithic. Different denominations choose their own political paths. Since 2014, the Union home ministry has cancelled many FCRA accounts operated by church NGOs.